

Even the best infrastructure and crores spent on development can be undone by poor governance. The parameters, therefore, to measure excellence in governance take in performance by elected political entities as well as the administration, which so often takes its cue from the political class. MLAs' criminal records, the tiered structure of panchayats, e-services provided by state governments/ panchayats, and the ingress of the 'Digital India' programme in the vast hinterlands and other factors were taken into account to arrive at India Today's State of the States rankings for governance.

Best Performing Big State: Maharashtra

Maharashtra battled with the pandemic and natural calamities in 2021. The partial lockdown depleted the state exchequer; excessive rain and floods put an additional burden on it. However, the state's administration held firm. In education, Maharashtra's record is robust. At 96, it had the most number of universities per 1 million people in 2021-22. The same goes for healthcare. During the second Covid wave, it arranged 12,000 tonnes of medical oxygen for patients, the highest in the country. The state's rational approach on relaxing restrictions helped get the economy back on track—the decision not to curb economic activities in areas with a low Covid infection count boosted recovery. During this turbulent period, Maharashtra's unemployment rate was 4.5 per cent, only second to Gujarat's 1.5 per cent.

MANIPUR HAS AN ENVIABLE RECORD IN E-SERVICES, WOMEN IN PANCHAYATS AND DIGITAL GOVERNANCE

Best Performing Small State: Manipur

In almost all parameters examined to assess the performance under this category, Manipur has done exceptionally well. With cent per cent gram panchayats providing e-services, it is among the best in India; for every 100,000 individuals, there are 29 operational Common Service Centres, the highest among all small states. The state has rolled out 35 e-services, the second highest in the Northeast and fourth highest among all states. In women's participation, it is exceptional—over 50 per cent panchayat representatives are women, the highest among small states. For Chief Minister N. Biren Singh, technical intervention has been a key tool of governance, enabling an equitable distribution of the fruits of development. Not surprisingly, Manipur is the first state to have set up the four-core infrastructure of the National e-Governance Plan. "The primary objective of a government is

BEST PERFORMING BIG STATES GOVERNANCE

RANK 2022	STATE	SCORE OUT OF 120	RANK 2021
1	MAHARASHTRA	97.2	2
2	WEST BENGAL	91.1	3
3	HARYANA	91.0	5
4	RAJASTHAN	87.7	1
4	MADHYA PRADESH	87.7	3
6	TAMIL NADU	87.1	8
7	CHHATTISGARH	86.6	6
8	HIMACHAL PRADESH	84.6	10
9	GUJARAT	81.2	7
10	ANDHRA PRADESH	79.6	9
11	UTTAR PRADESH	77.4	12
12	JHARKHAND	75.8	13
13	BIHAR	75.1	17
14	UTTARAKHAND	74.1	14
15	ASSAM	68.8	16
16	KARNATAKA	68.6	15
17	KERALA	67.6	11
18	TELANGANA	65.2	18
19	ODISHA	62.3	19
20	PUNJAB	49.1	20

BEST PERFORMING SMALL STATES GOVERNANCE

RANK 2022	STATE	SCORE OUT OF 120	RANK 2021
1	MANIPUR	54.9	1
2	PUDUCHERRY	49.3	3
3	DELHI	47.8	2
4	TRIPURA	41.1	6
5	SIKKIM	40.5	4
6	MIZORAM	33.7	5
7	GOA	29.8	7
8	MEGHALAYA	28.3	9
9	NAGALAND	27.8	8
10	ARUNACHAL PRADESH	14.4	10

Parameters: Criminal Records of MLAs, % of women representatives in Panchayats, Panchayat Devolution Index, Number of e-services rolled out by state governments for citizen participation, number